

M.A. in Music: where to start

For prospective graduate students · fall 2027 entry



M.A. in Music page

Degree	Length	Emphases	Contact
Master of Arts in Music	32 units, four semesters	Performance (Classical or Jazz), Choral Conducting, Composition	Inés Thiebaut, Graduate Coordinator

01 The program

The Master of Arts in Music is a 32-unit degree completed in four semesters of full-time study. Every student takes a shared seminar core in analysis and post-tonal practice, the history and theory of jazz, interdisciplinary collaboration, advanced conducting, the social and ecological dimensions of music, entrepreneurship in the arts, and teaching music in higher education. You take applied lessons and an ensemble in your area of emphasis every semester. The degree ends with a public capstone and a comprehensive examination.

You declare one area of emphasis when you apply. Performance, in the classical or the jazz track, ends in a capstone recital. Choral Conducting is advanced conducting study with the Department's choral ensembles and ends in a capstone conducting performance. Composition is the creation of a body of original acoustic and electroacoustic work and ends in a public capstone lecture on your portfolio.

Roadmap and
graduate
handbook

02 Preparation

A bachelor's degree in music is the usual preparation for the M.A. Applications without one are read case by case. You need good academic standing at your most recent college or university.

03 How to apply

1. Write to the Graduate Coordinator with questions about your preparation, your emphasis, or the fit of the program, before you apply or at any point along the way.
2. Apply to CSU East Bay through Cal State Apply, choosing the M.A. in Music.
3. Ask every college and university you've attended to send official transcripts to the Office of Admissions, electronically to electronictranscripts@csueastbay.edu. Track what's outstanding in MyCSUEB.
4. Submit the Department's materials:
 - a CV or résumé
 - two letters of recommendation from teachers or colleagues who can speak to your readiness for graduate work (you enter their names and email addresses in Cal State Apply, and each receives a form and an upload link)
 - a 2-page statement of purpose on what you want from a graduate degree in music and where you're headed in the short and long term
 - evidence of your work in your area of emphasis, as set out on the Department's How to Apply page
5. Check the graduate application and document deadlines for the term you're applying to.



Cal State Apply

How to Apply, M.A.
materialsTranscripts and
documentsGraduate
deadlines

04 Paying for the degree

The Department awards music scholarships to entering students every year from the materials already in the application. There is no separate scholarship application.

The graduate program offers a limited number of paid teaching appointments. Graduate Teaching Associates lead classroom or lab sections and are paid per course unit assigned. Instructional Student Assistants support teaching through grading and tutoring, up to 20 hours a week. Assignments open before each semester: tell the Graduate Coordinator early if either interests you.

The Office of Graduate Studies runs fellowships, research funding, and other support across the University. M.A. students apply for federal and state financial aid through the Office of Financial Aid.



Music scholarships

05 Certificate in Music Education

Admission to the M.A. makes you eligible to begin the Certificate in Music Education, which you can complete alongside the degree. The certificate covers the coursework that prepares you to apply for the California Single Subject Teaching Credential in Music. It doesn't confer the credential. Taken on its own, the certificate isn't eligible for federal or state financial aid; taken with the M.A., it is. John Eros coordinates music education (john.eros@csueastbay.edu), and the Graduate Coordinator fits the certificate to the graduate sequence.



Music education

06 Already in the B.A. at East Bay

Current CSU East Bay B.A. in Music students can apply to the FAST 4+1 B.A./M.A. in the junior year and complete both degrees in five years, with a set of graduate courses counting toward both. Second-bachelor's students and double majors aren't eligible for FAST.



FAST 4+1

07 Visit and contacts

Sit in on a seminar, hear a rehearsal, and meet the faculty and the students in the program. Write to the Graduate Coordinator to arrange a visit around your schedule.

Office	Contact
Graduate Coordinator	Inés Thiebaut · MB 2012 · (510) 885-3126 · ines.thiebaut@csueastbay.edu
Music office	MB 2569 · (510) 885-3135 · music@csueastbay.edu
Office of Graduate Studies	(510) 885-3716 · gradstudies@csueastbay.edu

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